

Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

July 2026

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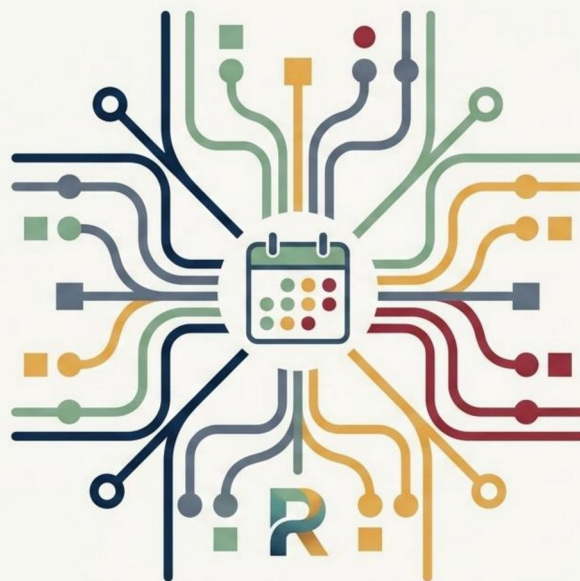
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Quick Start Guide — Orchestrating with Empathy

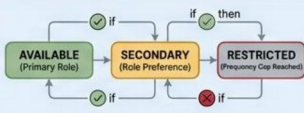
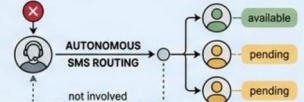
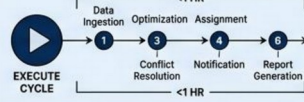
Orchestrating with Empathy

The Rostas Playbook for
Coordinators at Knox
Church Waitara
May 2026



NotebookLM

Transitioning from static scheduling to a dynamic engine

Legacy Manual Systems	The Rostas Engine
 Flat Availability: Volunteers are treated as a simple 'yes' or 'no'.	 Granular Logic: Utilizes three availability states, primary/secondary role preferences, and strict frequency caps.
 Coordinator Intervention: Cancellations require the coordinator to act as a middleman, sending emails and making phone calls to find replacements.	 Automated Autonomy: Cancellations trigger an autonomous SMS replacement chain that routes around the coordinator directly to available backups.
 Vulnerable to Burnout: Relies heavily on the same few volunteers, often leading to quiet resignations.	 Protected Energy: The engine enforces monthly limits and tracks historical scheduling to ensure fair rotation.
 High Administrative Load: A single roster cycle requires two to three hours of manual data entry and cross-referencing.	 Orchestrated Efficiency: A full cycle is reduced to under an hour through a six-step, single-button workflow.

NotebookLM

System access is purposefully distilled to protect data integrity

	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Tech Support
Sync roster types	✓	✓	✓
View/Edit volunteer data	✓	✓	✓
Build/Edit rosters	✓	✓	✓
Manage Replacements	✓	✓	✓
Sync volunteers from Infoodle		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster types		✓	✓
Apps Script / Technical changes			✓

Note: Infoodle remains the ultimate source of truth. Name changes and new volunteer additions must be processed in Infoodle before syncing to Rostas.

NotebookLM

The roster follows a strict, sequential seven-step sequence



NotebookLM

Step 0 & 1 establish a synchronised foundation before processing availability

Step 0: Refresh the Seasons Calendar

0. Refresh calendar

Function: Recalculates all roster dates and overlays New Zealand public and school holidays.



Rule: This must be run after editing any season start or end dates, or at the exact beginning of a new roster cycle.

Step 1: Sync Volunteers from Infoodle

1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle

Function: Pulls fresh volunteer data and group memberships. (Runs automatically at 2:00 AM daily, but can be triggered manually).



Warning: Rostas strictly reads from Infoodle. If a volunteer is missing, they must be added to the Infoodle database first.

NotebookLM

Step 2 captures exact role preferences to optimize assignments

Volunteers are sent a personalised link to set their preferences for the season. This prevents the system from assigning a volunteer to a role they are unqualified for or uncomfortable performing.

The Three-Tier Preference System:

- 1. **Primary Roles:** The default, preferred tasks a volunteer enjoys.
- 2. **Backup Roles:** Tasks a volunteer is capable of, but prefers not to do regularly ("Happy to fill in").
- ✖ 3. **Excluded Roles:** Tasks the volunteer cannot perform. The engine will strictly ignore these candidates for these roles.

Coordinators can also manually set these preferences via the editable 'Preferred Roles' list in the Rostas desktop view for volunteers who do not use the web link.



NotebookLM

Frequency caps strictly protect volunteer energy and prevent burnout

Frequency settings control the maximum number of times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a specific roster type.

- The defaults are set to 4 for weekly rosters and 2 for fortnightly rosters.
- Coordinators can adjust this downward in the 'Volunteer Details' view for individuals needing a lighter load.
- Notes can be added to clarify specific arrangements (e.g., "4th Monday only").

Max Days Rostered

1 2 3 **4** Days Per Month



Insight

The Engine Rule: The automated system strictly enforces this monthly maximum. Once a cap is reached, the system will actively bypass the volunteer for the remainder of the month, even if they have explicitly marked themselves as "Available" for those dates.

NotebookLM

Step 3 gathers precise availability via a three-state selection process

Volunteers receive a personalised availability link. Everything defaults to "Available" — volunteers only need to interact with dates they cannot make.

✓
Available

?
Unsure

✗
Can't make it

The Automated Nudge Protocol:

1. Send: Availability emails are dispatched via the Run Commands dashboard.

2. Wait: The system waits the configured duration (default: 2 days).

3. Evaluate: A daily background process identifies non-responders.

4. Nudge: An SMS reminder with a direct link is sent automatically.

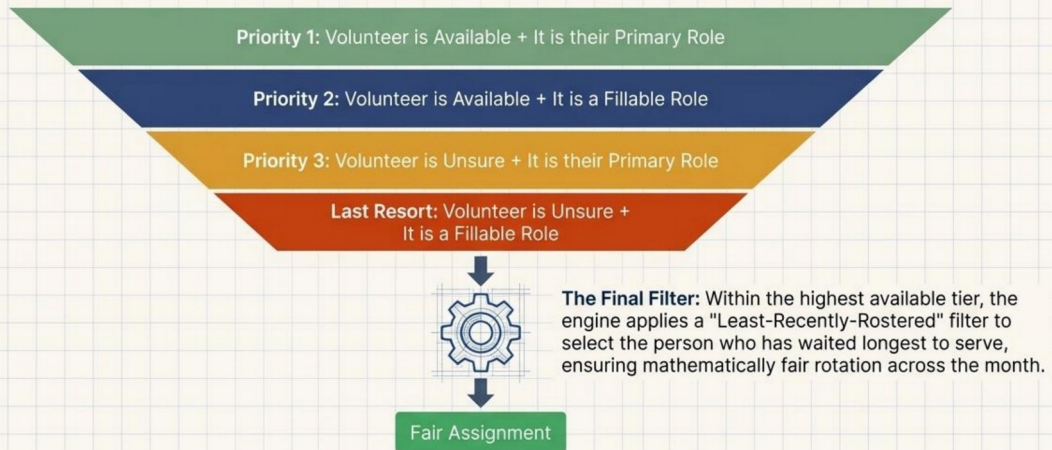


This fires exactly once per cycle to respect the volunteer's inbox. Opted-out volunteers are silently skipped.

NotebookLM

The Roster Engine logic synthesizes availability, preferences, and history

When Step 4 ("Build Roster") is triggered, the system does not fill slots blindly. It filters every volunteer through a strict four-tier priority matrix:



NotebookLM

Step 4 & 5 require auditing the output via the Traffic Light UI

Rostas builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default. Before proceeding, coordinators must inspect the Global Roster view.

Step 4 Audit: Global Roster Day view

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 Mon 18, 3AM-12PM ✓	2 Mon 19, 1PM-4PM ✓	3	4	5	6	7
18	19 Tue 19, 10AM-1PM ✗	20	21 Thu 21, 10AM-1PM ✓	22 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM ✓	23	24
18	19 Tue 19, 1PM-4PM ✓	20 Wed 20, 3PM-6PM ?	21	22 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM ✓	23 Sat 23, 11AM-2PM ?	24 Sun 24, 3AM-12PM ✓
25	26	27	28	29	30	1

The Status Indicators:

- ✓ **Green (Filled):** A solid assignment.
- ? **Amber (Pending):** An assignment where the volunteer marked themselves 'Unsure'.
- ✗ **Red (Unfilled):** The engine could not find an available volunteer. These require manual coordinator intervention to locate a substitute or adjust role requirements.

Step 5 Preview: Comms Dashboard



Step 5 (Preview Communications):

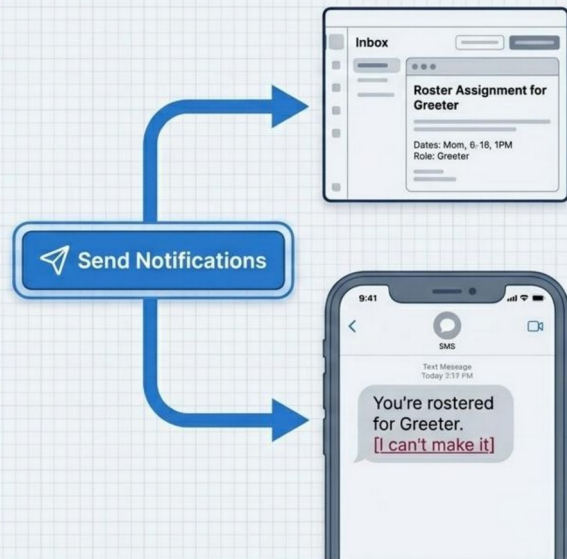
Utilize the Comms Dashboard to preview the exact wording, dates, and layouts of all pending emails and SMS notifications before dispatching them.

NotebookLM

Step 6 dispatches all confirmed assignments instantly

With a single tap on "Send Notifications" in the Run Commands view, Rostas dispatches assignments to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending status.

- The volunteer receives an email detailing their role and dates.
- A corresponding SMS is sent simultaneously.
- Pending volunteers receive explicit "Yes, I can make it" and "Can't make it" confirmation buttons to lock in their status.
- All communications include a "Can't make it" fail-safe link to handle unexpected changes.

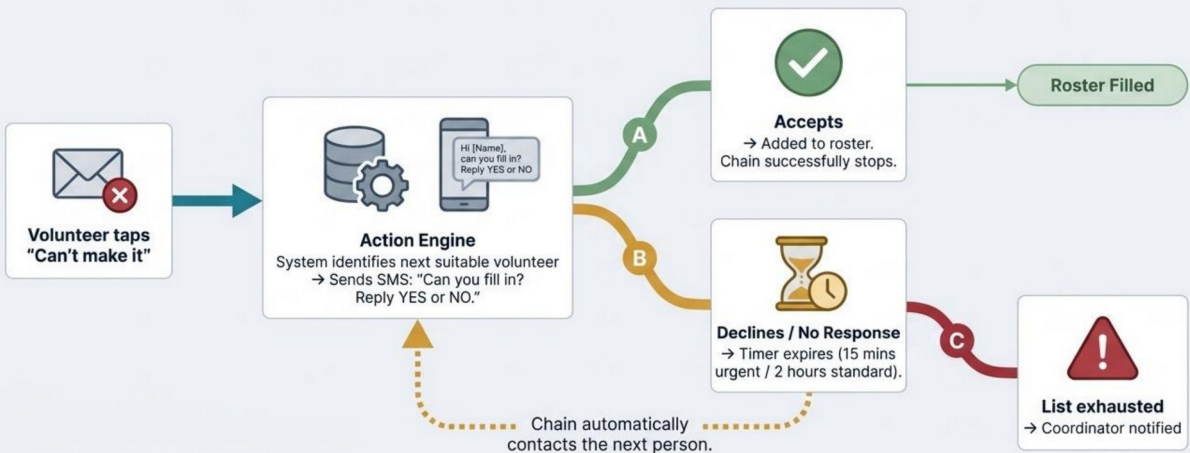


NotebookLM

The automated SMS chain executes stress-free replacements

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it', the coordinator is removed from the friction of finding a replacement. The system takes over immediately.

 System Parameter:
SMS traffic pauses
automatically between
9:00 PM and 8:00 AM
NZ time to respect
volunteers' privacy.

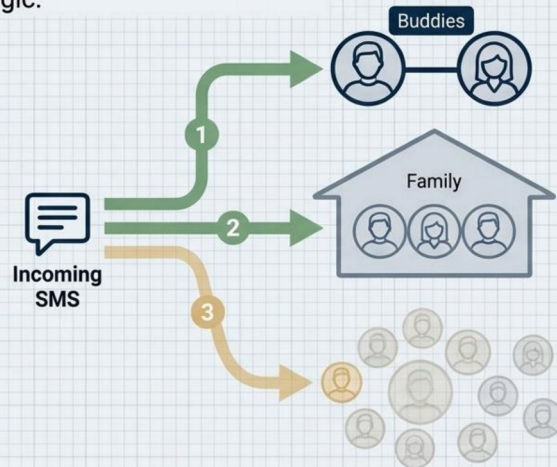


NotebookLM

Relational Rostering aligns households and preferred buddies

An advanced feature activated via the Quick Controls panel, Relational Rostering adds an empathetic secondary pass to the engine logic.

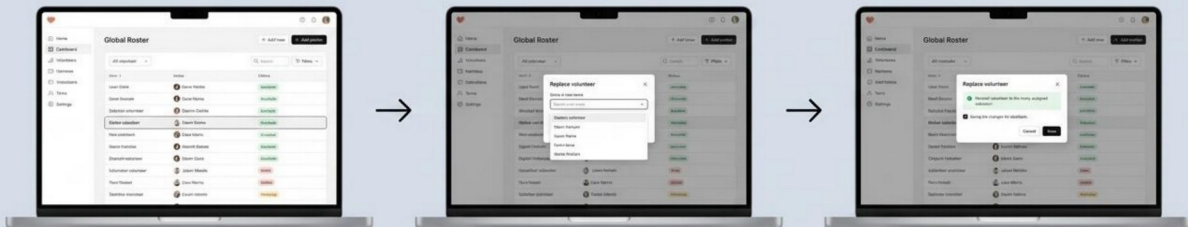
- **Household Pairing:** Parents and teenagers can be assigned to the same service dates, consolidating travel into a single car trip and simplifying family logistics.
- **Preferred Buddies:** Volunteers who prefer to work alongside a specific partner are paired together to increase retention and comfort.
- **Warm Replacements:** If a volunteer declines an assignment, the SMS replacement chain targets their preferred buddy or a household member first before contacting the broader candidate list.



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Manual interventions handle unexpected changes outside the automated loop

When a volunteer bypasses the system (e.g., phones the coordinator directly to cancel and nominates their own substitute), manual overrides are required.



1. Select

Selecting the specific roster slot in the Global Roster or Volunteer Details view.

2. Replace

Opening the 'Replace volunteer' dropdown modal to choose a specific substitute.

3. Save

Saving the changes. The new volunteer is instantly notified.

Alternative path: Select 'Save as Declined'. This marks the slot empty and intentionally hands the notification volunteer now and intentionally lands control back to the automated SMS chain to find a backup autonomously.

NotebookLM

Best Practices for Empathetic Rostering

Master the system by adhering to these four foundational rules:



1. Sync First

Always pull fresh Infoodle data and execute Step 0 upon making season changes before commanding a build.



2. Give Notice

Respect people's planning horizons by dispatching availability requests two to three weeks prior to a new season.



3. Review Before Sending

Never dispatch notifications blindly. Always audit the Global Roster for "Red" unfilled slots.



4. Trust the Chain

Resist the urge to micromanage cancellations. Allow the automated SMS system to handle sick calls and locate replacements autonomously.

Empower your volunteers. Simplify your scheduling.

NotebookLM

Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step Roster Wizard guides you through each stage in order:



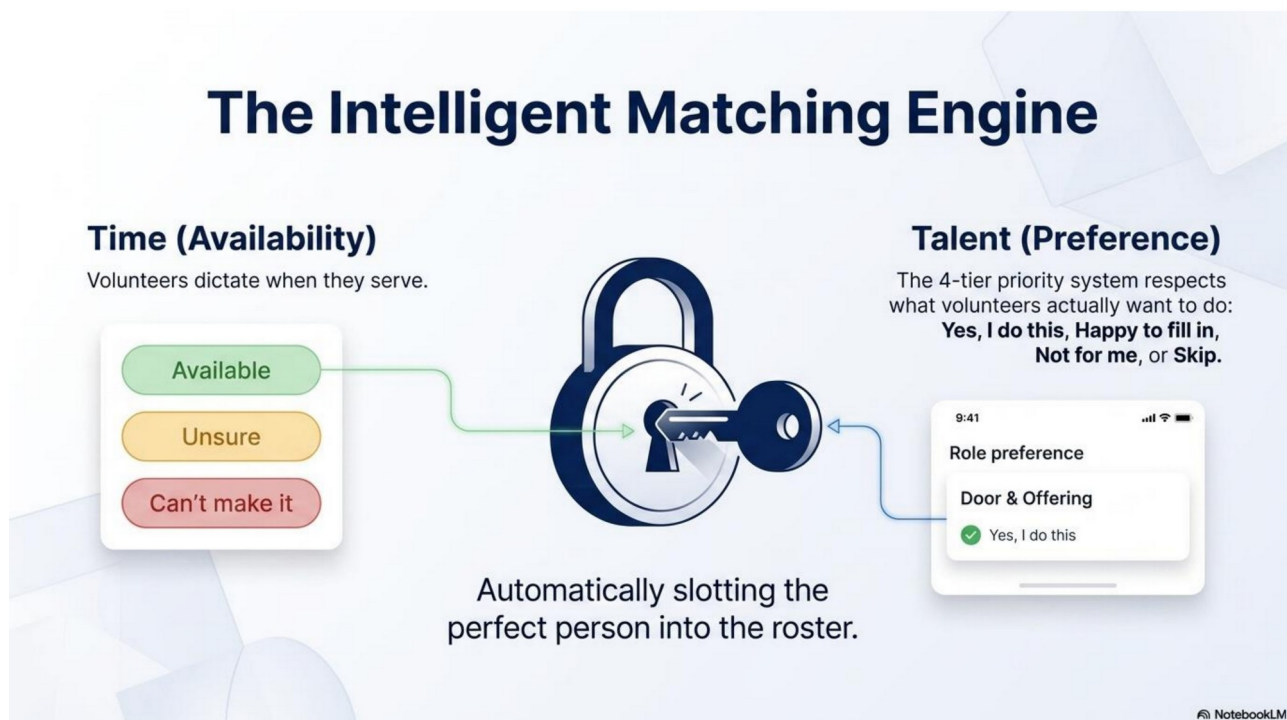
The six-step roster lifecycle. The Roster Wizard guides you through each step — each stage is triggered by a single button.

The Builds dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each roster type is a full-width row showing its current state, recent and upcoming dates, and a menu of actions. Click a row's state button to open its wizard.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas emails your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Volunteers receive a personalised link — no password, no app — and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.



Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

If a volunteer doesn't respond, Rostas sends an automatic SMS nudge after a configurable number of days. No manual chasing needed.

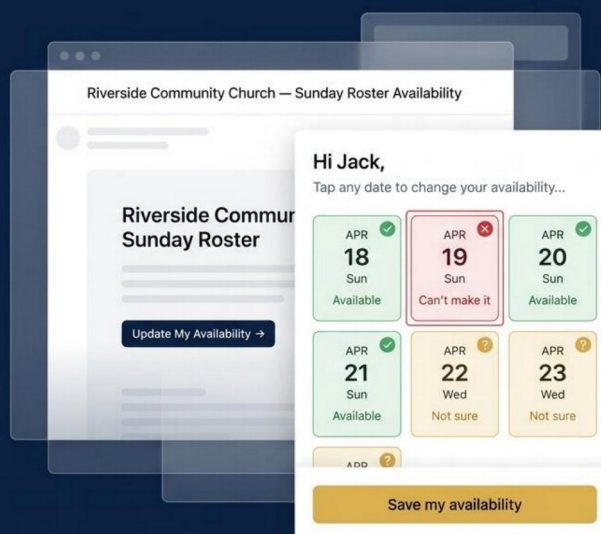
The Intelligent Matching Engine

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:

Frictionless Volunteer Experience

Volunteers receive a personalised link. Everything defaults to **Available**—they **only need** to tap the dates they cannot make.

- 🕒 If they forget to respond within a few days, Rostas automatically sends a configurable SMS nudge, saving the coordinator from manual follow-ups.



The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

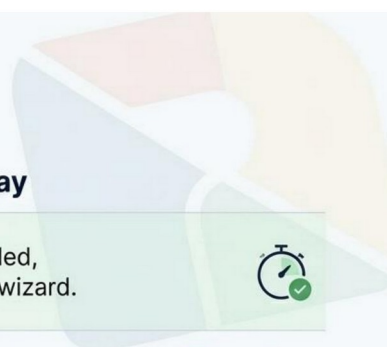
The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and take action. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap a link in their notification email. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.

A Paradigm Shift in Coordination

	The Manual System	The Rostas Way
Time Spent	2–3 hours of individual chasing.	<1 hour via a guided, button-triggered wizard. 
Availability	Flattened 'Yes/No' guesswork.	Nuanced 3-state availability + 4-tier role preferences. 
Cancellations	Coordinator manually calls around in a panic.	Automated SMS replacement sequence (respecting configurable quiet hours). 
Retention	High risk of volunteer burnout.	Automated frequency caps and self-serve opt-outs. 





Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.

The Automated SMS Cascade

The diagram illustrates the Automated SMS Cascade process through three sequential stages, each represented by a smartphone screen showing a text message conversation. The stages are connected by arrows, with a clock icon indicating a waiting period between the first and second stages.

- The Ask:** System identifies the next suitable, available volunteer. The message on the screen says: "Hi Jack, we've had a cancellation. Can you cover Door & Offering on Sunday 20th March? <https://roster.app/?t=abc123> If you haven't responded by Sunday 28th March at 6:00 PM we'll text the next person."
- The Wait:** Gives the volunteer time to respond. This stage is represented by a clock icon and an arrow pointing from the first stage to the second.
- The Acceptance:** Slot is filled automatically. The message on the screen says: "Thanks Jack for stepping up at short notice. You're rostered on Sunday 28th March for Door & Offering."
- The Release:** Original volunteer is relieved. The message on the screen says: "Hi Jack, no problem at all — we have found a replacement for Door & Offering on Sunday 29th March. — [OrgName] Roster Team."

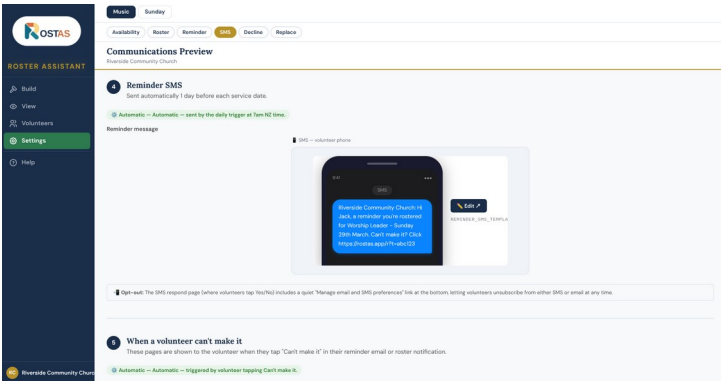
Quiet Hours Respected. SMS messages are blocked by default between 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM, holding messages in a queue so nobody is disturbed at

The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

Quiet hours are always respected. Rostas never sends automated SMS during your quiet hours. If the replacement chain reaches a volunteer during that window, it pauses and resumes automatically once quiet hours end. You set the start and end times in Settings → SMS (the default is 9pm–8am).

When Rostas needs a reply by text — a replacement request, a manual-roster heads-up, or a cross-roster ask — the message contains a **4-digit code**, not a link. New Zealand mobile networks silently filter many texts that contain web links, so a tappable link in an SMS can't be relied on to arrive. On SMS a short code does double duty: it survives carrier filtering *and* it's far shorter than a link, keeping each message inside the single-text limit so your church isn't charged for two.

The volunteer opens **rosta.s.app/enter** and types the 4-digit code from their text. The code is single-use and expires after a short window, so it can't be reused or forwarded. Once entered, they land on the same accept / decline page they'd have reached from a link.



What a replacement request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a clear message with a 4-digit code to enter at rosta.s.app/enter. There's no link in the text: NZ networks filter many link-bearing SMS, and a code keeps the message short and reliable.

The rostas.app/enter page — the volunteer types the 4-digit code from their text and taps Continue, reaching the same accept / decline page a link would have opened.

Email is unchanged. Email notifications aren't filtered and aren't charged per character, so they still contain ordinary tappable links — only SMS moved to

codes. Because the email carries the link and explains the entry page, it's how most volunteers first learn where rostas.app/enter is. They can bookmark it, and your church can link to it from your website behind the Rostas logo so it's always one tap away.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

Rostas doesn't replace your judgement. There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into six parts. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Builds dashboard on every future visit.

Before you start: Your Rostas coordinator needs to have set up the system and given you the link to open it. If you don't have a link yet, ask them for it.

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has four steps shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.



Organisation
Riverside Com...



Your Details
Sarah



SMS
+64211494306



Done



Your Organisation

This name appears in every message sent to volunteers.

Organisation name *

Riverside Community Church



26 / 40

Timezone *

New Zealand



Country / calling code *

+64 — New Zealand



Website (optional)

<https://riversidechurch.org.nz>

Next →

Step 1 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next** → when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 2 — Your Details

Step 2 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for SMS test sends, coordinator escalation alerts when the replacement chain is exhausted, and the bottom of the coordinator app sidebar.

**Organisation**
Riverside Com...

**Your Details**
Sarah

**SMS**
+64211494306

**Done**



Your Details

Used in the top bar, test SMS sends, and coordinator alerts.

Your name *

Your email *

Your mobile *

Include your country code — e.g. +6421123456

[← Back](#)[Next →](#)

Step 2 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Include your country code in the mobile number. Enter it as +6421123456, not 021123456. Without the country code SMS delivery will fail.

Step 3 — SMS Test

Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.

Step 3 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 3

Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap **Send test SMS** → and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received, a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.



Organisation
Riverside Com...



Your Details
Sarah



SMS
+64211494306



Done



Let's make sure SMS is working

Send a test message before your first roster build.

Your SMS connection is configured. Send a test message to confirm everything is working.

Send test SMS to

+6421785876

☑ Message received — SMS is ready

← Back

Re-send test SMS

Next →

When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

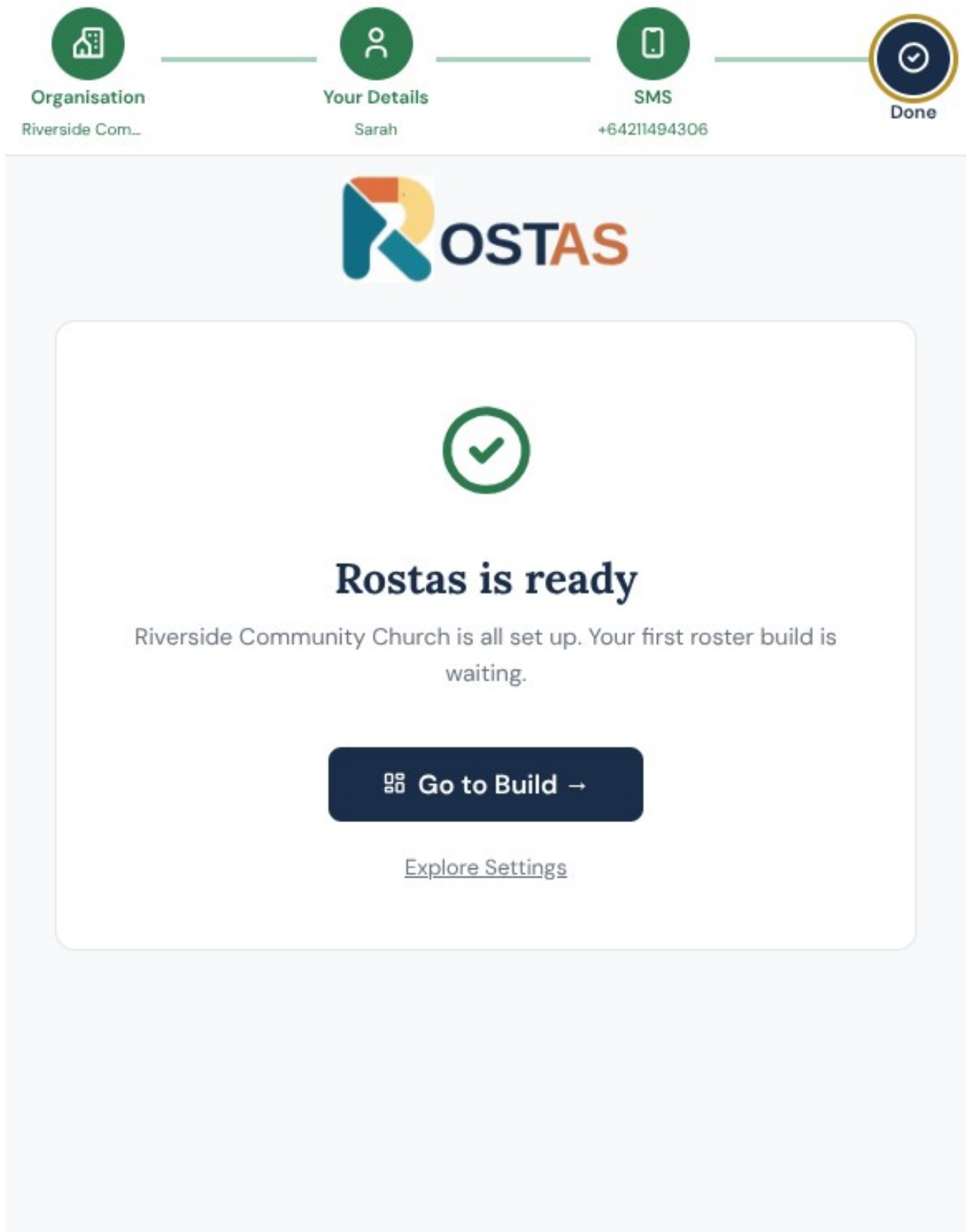
If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number includes the country code and is entered correctly. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, email support@rostar.app —

SMS sending is set up by Rostas, not something you configure yourself.

If SMS isn't set up on your copy yet, Step 3 shows a "SMS isn't set up yet" screen instead of the test send, with a link to support@rosta.app and a **Continue without SMS** button. You can finish setup and start using Rostas by email — replacement requests and reminders begin working once SMS is switched on. For most churches SMS is already configured before you receive your copy, so you'll see the test-send screen above.

Step 4 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.



"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Builds dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Builds dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before your first build.

What's Next

Rostas is set up. Next, get your volunteers in: head to **Part C — Profiles** to import or add them and set up how each one serves. Once your profiles are in, **Part D — The Roster Cycle** walks you through building your first roster.

- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- ✓ Volunteers imported or added
- ○ Volunteer role preferences set (can be done during the wizard)

The Volunteers section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Profiles** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

Importing your volunteers from CSV

The quickest way to get your volunteers into Rostas is to import a spreadsheet — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list. This is how most organisations start. If your volunteers already live in another system, you may be able to sync them automatically instead — see the Connector Appendix.

Open the **Profiles** list and click **Import Volunteer CSV** on the toolbar. The import runs in three steps.

Step 1 — choose the spreadsheet file to import.

Step 2 — Rostas matches the columns it recognises automatically; review the rest, map any it wasn't sure about, and check the preview before committing.

Step 3 — a confirmation of how many volunteers were imported. They appear in the Profiles list straight away.

Your CSV needs at minimum a name and a mobile number. Email is strongly recommended so volunteers can receive availability requests and notifications. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type, map it during the import and volunteers are assigned to the right rosters automatically. Phone numbers missing a country code are corrected for you.

Adding a volunteer manually

For one-offs — a single new volunteer between imports — click **Add Volunteer** on the Profiles toolbar. Fill in their details and save; they appear in the list immediately and can be included in your next build.

New volunteer details

FULL NAME *

MOBILE PHONE *

Local numbers are converted automatically e.g. 0211234567 → +64211234567

EMAIL

ROSTER TYPES *

☐ Sunday ☐ Music

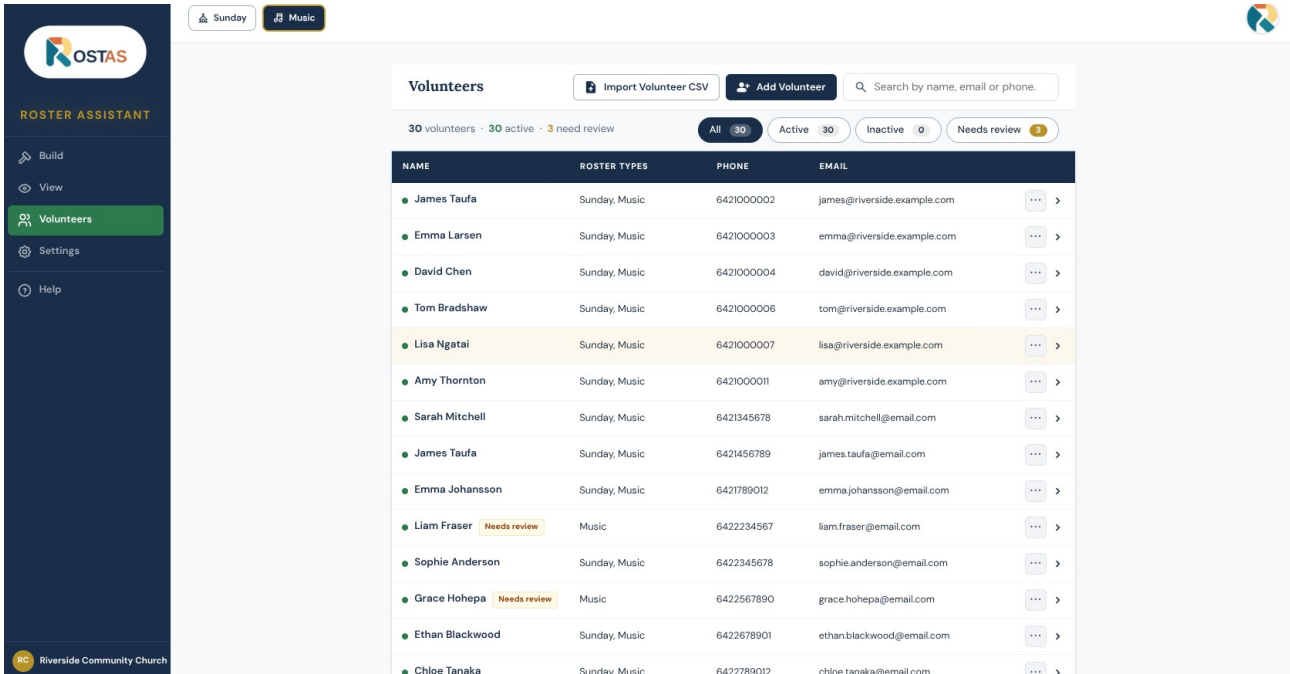
Select at least one roster this volunteer will be part of

The Add Volunteer form — name, mobile, email, and which roster types they serve in.

Mobile number format matters. Enter numbers in full international format including country code — e.g. +6421123456, not 021123456. Incorrectly formatted numbers fail to receive SMS silently.

The volunteers list

Once your volunteers are in, the Profiles list shows everyone — name, roster types, phone, and email — in one place. Search by name, email, or phone, or filter by Active, Inactive, or All using the chips below the search bar. Click any row to open that volunteer's profile.



The screenshot displays the 'Volunteers' section of the Roster Assistant application. On the left is a dark sidebar with the 'ROSTAS' logo and navigation links: Build, View, **Volunteers**, Settings, and Help. The main area has a top bar with 'Sunday' and 'Music' tabs, and a 'Volunteers' title. Below the title are buttons for 'Import Volunteer CSV' and 'Add Volunteer', and a search bar. A summary bar shows '30 volunteers · 30 active · 3 need review' and filter chips for 'All (30)', 'Active (30)', 'Inactive (0)', and 'Needs review (3)'. The main table lists volunteers with columns for Name, Roster Types, Phone, and Email. Each row has a green dot icon and a 'Needs review' badge. The table data is as follows:

NAME	ROSTER TYPES	PHONE	EMAIL
James Taufa	Sunday, Music	6421000002	james@riverside.example.com
Emma Larsen	Sunday, Music	6421000003	emma@riverside.example.com
David Chen	Sunday, Music	6421000004	david@riverside.example.com
Tom Bradshaw	Sunday, Music	6421000006	tom@riverside.example.com
Lisa Ngatai	Sunday, Music	6421000007	lisa@riverside.example.com
Amy Thornton	Sunday, Music	6421000011	amy@riverside.example.com
Sarah Mitchell	Sunday, Music	6421345678	sarah.mitchell@email.com
James Taufa	Sunday, Music	6421456789	james.taufa@email.com
Emma Johansson	Sunday, Music	6421789012	emma.johansson@email.com
Liam Fraser	Music	6422234567	liam.fraser@email.com
Sophie Anderson	Sunday, Music	6422345678	sophie.anderson@email.com
Grace Hohepa	Music	6422567890	grace.hohepa@email.com
Ethan Blackwood	Sunday, Music	6422678901	ethan.blackwood@email.com
Chloe Tanaka	Sunday, Music	6422789012	chloe.tanaka@email.com

The Profiles list — everyone in one place. The toolbar holds Import Volunteer CSV and Add Volunteer; click any row to open a profile.

Click any row to open that volunteer's full profile — where you edit their details, set the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with, and view their availability.

The Profile Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their profile. This is where you manage everything about that person — their contact details, which rosters they serve in, the roles they do, how often they serve, who they serve alongside, and their availability. The left panel holds their contact details and a tab per roster type; the right panel holds the settings for whichever roster tab is selected, so each roster a volunteer serves in has its own independent setup.

Contact details & toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and status, with four toggles that control how Rostas treats them:

The left panel's toggles. "Always text too" is the newest — it opts a volunteer in to reminder texts even when they'd normally be reached by email.

Roles — what they do

The Roles section on the right panel is where you set which roles this volunteer performs in this roster. Each role shows as **Does This**, **Fills In**, or **Doesn't Do** — the same distinction the matching engine uses as Primary, Fillable, and not-for-me (see Part A, The Intelligent Matching Engine).

The Roles section. Set each role to Does This (a primary role they do regularly), Fills In (they'll cover it when needed), or Doesn't Do.

Linking roles together

Sometimes two roles should travel together — whoever runs the sound desk also runs the projection, say, or a married couple should always be on setup as a pair. Role linking handles this. Both roles must be set to **Does This** first; then click the link icon () on a role card to open a dropdown of roles you can link it to, and choose the link type.

Clicking a role's link icon lists the other roles it can be linked to.

After picking a role, choose the link type — Dominant—Shadow or Equal Pairing.

Linked roles are ringed on the profile so you can see the relationship at a glance: a **gold ring** marks the dominant role, a **grey ring** its shadow, and a **dark-green ring** an equal pair. On the Board, the matching assignment cards carry the same colours.

On the Board, a linked pair's cards share a colour — so a linked assignment is easy to spot.

To change or remove a link, click the link icon on an already-linked role — the dropdown then shows the linked partner and an option to unlink.

Frequency — how often they serve

The Frequency control — labelled **ONCE EVERY** — caps how often this volunteer is rostered in this roster, so nobody is over-used even when they're always available. Tap a pill: **No cap**, or once every **1wk** through **12wk**.

The Frequency control. "No cap" lets the engine roster them as often as needed; "4wk" means at most once every four weeks, and so on.

The cap counts distinct service dates, not roles. A volunteer rostered to two roles on the same day counts as one service — so serving twice in one Sunday doesn't use up two of their allocation.

Relational rostering — serving together

Relational rostering asks Rostas to place people *together* on the same dates — a **Buddy** they like to serve alongside, or a **Household** so family members share the same rota. Turn on "Serves With" and pick who.

Relational rostering — Buddy and Household "Serves With" settings, so people who want to serve together are scheduled together.

Relational rostering is not the same as role linking. Role linking ties two *roles* together on one person; relational rostering places two *people* on the same dates. One is about jobs, the other about company.

Next roster availability

The availability grid shows this volunteer's responses for the upcoming dates — the same three states they set on their own form:

The Next Roster Availability grid. Holiday dates are tagged automatically so you can see at a glance which dates are affected.

If the season's dates aren't confirmed yet, an amber banner appears at the bottom of this section — availability can't be collected until the dates are set. Confirm the season first (Part D) and the grid fills in.

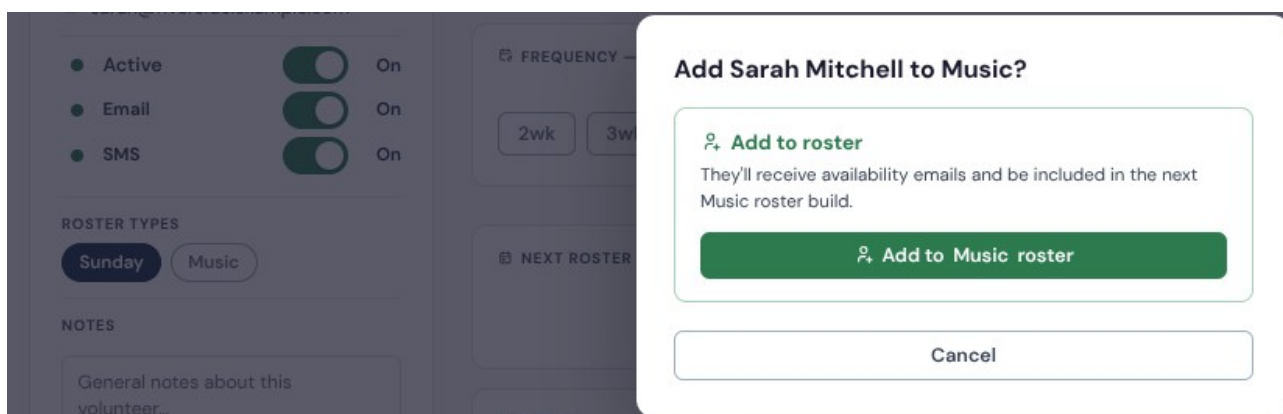
The season-dates-unconfirmed banner — a reminder to confirm the season before availability can be gathered.

Searching across rosters. The prev/next arrows at the top of the profile step through volunteers. Next to them is a search-scope toggle — switch it on to search across every roster rather than just the current one.

The profile top bar — step between volunteers with the arrows, and widen the search to all rosters with the scope toggle.

Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster

If a volunteer starts serving in an additional roster type, click the inactive roster tab on their detail page. A confirmation dialog appears — confirm to add them to that roster. Their settings for the new roster start fresh and can be configured from the right panel.



Clicking an inactive roster tab shows a confirmation before adding the volunteer. Once confirmed they appear in that roster's volunteer pool at the next build.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas entirely through personalised links sent by email or SMS — no login, no app to download. There are three volunteer-facing pages:

Riverside Community Church

YOUR UPCOMING ROSTER



YOUR LOGO

Dear Jack,

Thank you for your willingness to serve at [OrgName]. Here are your upcoming roster assignments:

Sunday, 29 March 2026

☒ **You're Rostered On**

Door & Offering

☒ **Can't make it**

Sunday, 5 April 2026

☐ **Can you make it?**

Baking for Morning Tea

☒ **Yes, I can make it**

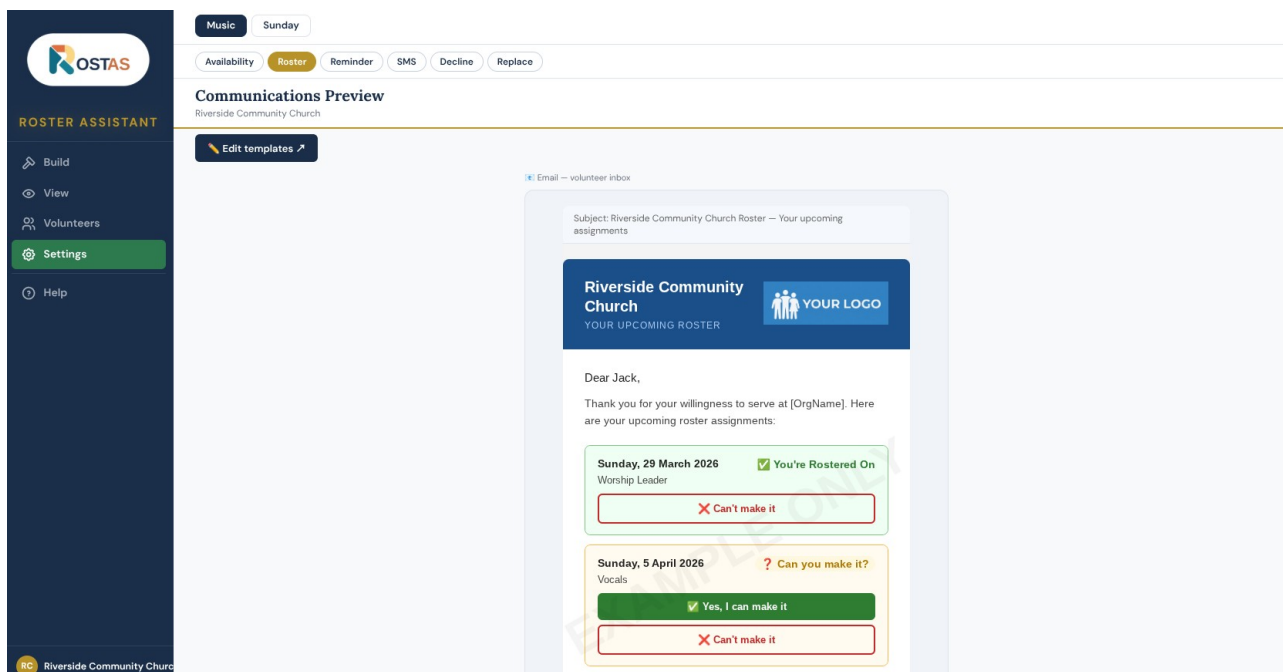
☒ **Can't make it**

Please plan to arrive a few minutes early so everything is ready before the service begins. If you have any questions, get in touch with **Sarah Mitchell** at coordinator@knoxwaitara.org.nz.



View My Roster

The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.



The roster notification email — every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments. The "Can't make it?" button at the bottom starts the replacement chain if tapped.

All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised. Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS. No app installation, no account creation — just a tap.

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. The **New Roster Wizard** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. The **Roster Wizard** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Builds dashboard**.

The Builds Dashboard

The Builds dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. Open it by clicking **Builds** in the sidebar. Every roster type appears as a full-width row — one per roster — so you can see the state of your whole operation at a glance and act on any roster without leaving the page.

The Builds dashboard — each roster type is a full-width row. On the left, a state button tells you where that roster is in its cycle and what clicking will do; along the row, a date-chip strip shows recent and upcoming service dates; on the right, the ... menu holds per-roster actions.

The state button

The button on the left of each row is dynamic — its colour and label tell you exactly where that roster is in its cycle, and clicking it always picks up at the right next step. You never have to remember where you left off.

The date-chip strip

Each row shows a strip of small date chips — the roster's recent and upcoming service dates. The colours are deliberately simple: **blue means a date that has already passed**, and **green means an upcoming date**. It's an at-a-glance sense of where each roster sits in time.

These two colours aren't the same as the date bands in the wizard.

On the Builds dashboard, chip colour just means past (blue) or upcoming (green). Inside the Confirm Dates step of a build you'll see a richer set of coloured bands for last build, this build, next build, and excluded dates — that's a different view with a different job.

The ... menu

The ... menu on the right of each row holds the actions you take on a roster between builds. Click it to open a pop-up of options.

The ... menu open on a roster row. When a roster is paused, the top option reads "Resume roster" instead of "Pause roster".

Deleting a roster asks you to confirm, and lists exactly what will be removed — seasons, roles, assignments, and preferences, with real counts. It also nudges you toward pausing instead if you only need a temporary break.

Deleting is permanent. If you only need to stop a roster for a while — over summer, say — use **Pause** from the ... menu instead. Pausing keeps all the roster's history and settings; deleting removes them for good.

Starting a brand-new roster type? A **New Roster** option on the Builds dashboard sets one up from scratch. See the New Roster Wizard section below.

The New Roster Wizard

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

You only run the New Roster Wizard once per roster type. After setup is complete, all future roster builds use the Roster Wizard instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — keep it brief and clear.

Step 1 — name your roster. This name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality".

After naming the roster, choose an icon that represents it. The icon appears on the roster's row on the Builds dashboard and beside its name in the app.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required. You can add, rename, or retire roles later from Managing Roles.

Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

Role names matter. Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.

Step 3 — set up your first season. Choose day of week, frequency, and date range. Projected dates appear as pills below — school holidays are labelled automatically so you can see which dates will be paused.

Step 4 — Volunteers

Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Tick each volunteer you want to include. Only volunteers already in Rostas appear here — if someone is missing, add them in Profiles first then return to this step.

Step 4 — tick each volunteer who serves in this roster. Use the search field to find someone quickly if you have a large list. You can also import additional volunteers via CSV from this step.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, icon, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.

New Roster Step 5 of 5

LOCK UP ROLES SEASON VOLUNTEERS REVIEW

Almost done!
Review everything below before creating your roster. Click any **Edit** link to go back and change a section — your other settings will be preserved. Once you click **Create Roster**, the roster will be active and ready to build.

[Hide tips](#)

Review: Lock Up

ROSTER	Lock Up	Edit
DAY	Sunday	Edit
FREQUENCY	Weekly	Edit
SEASON	Lock Up_Build_1_Jun_2026 Sun Jun 28 2026 00:00:00 GMT+1200 (New Zealand Standard Time) – Sun Aug 02 2026 00:00:00 GMT+1200 (New Zealand Standard Time)	Edit
HOLIDAY PAUSES	None	Edit
ROLES	Lock Back Gate & Building 1-1	Edit
VOLUNTEERS	4 added	Edit

[Back](#) [Create Roster](#)

Riverside Community Church

Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

Click **Confirm & Create Roster** to finish. Your new roster type appears on the Builds dashboard immediately. You're now ready to run your first Roster Wizard for this roster.

Managing Roles

Once a roster exists, you can add, rename, re-size, or retire its roles at any time. Open the **Builds** dashboard, click the **⋮** menu on the roster's row, and choose **Manage roles**. The page lists every role for that roster with its headcount and an active switch.

The Manage roles page — each role shows its Headcount (the minimum and maximum people to roster) and an Active / Inactive switch. The engine always tries to fill the minimum and never exceeds the maximum.

Changes apply from your next build onward. Renaming a role, changing its headcount, switching it active or inactive, or adding a new role all take effect at the next build — dates you've already built keep their original roles and wording. Nothing changes underneath the volunteers you've already notified.

Deactivate rather than delete. Deactivating a role keeps the full history of who served in it; it just stops appearing in new builds. Reach for deactivate unless you're correcting a genuine setup mistake.

Mind the timing when renaming mid-cycle. Because a rename only affects messages sent after it, volunteers already notified will have the old name in their earlier email or text. If you rename partway through a cycle, expect a brief mismatch until the next build.

Frequency & Season Type

There are two separate frequency ideas in Rostas: how often the *roster* runs, and how often each *volunteer* serves. This section covers the roster side — its cadence and whether the season is fixed or ongoing. The per-volunteer cap is set on each person's profile (see Frequency on the Profile detail page); the two are explained together at the end.

Roster cadence — how often the roster runs

Not every roster runs weekly. A community meal might run fortnightly, a kids' ministry only on the 1st and 3rd Sunday, a review team monthly. The **Frequency** page sets this cadence per roster type — it decides which dates appear in the season, and therefore which dates Rostas builds for. You reach it two ways: when you first create a roster (in the New Roster Wizard's first step), or any time afterwards from the Builds dashboard — ... — Frequency.

The Frequency page — cadence pills across the top, and the Season Type control below. Changes apply from your next roster build onward; dates already built keep their original cadence.

Cadence is set once per roster type and applies to everyone in it. If two groups run on different weeks, set them up as separate roster types.

Season type — fixed-term or perpetual

Below the cadence pills, the **Season Type** control decides whether this roster has an end or simply keeps going:

Perpetual seasons roll forward on their own — the end date is maintained by Rostas, so you never have to extend them. Most ongoing church rosters (Sunday service, welcome team) suit Perpetual. If you later need a

perpetual roster to stop on a set date, switch it to Fixed-term and give it an end date.

Volunteer frequency cap — how often a person serves

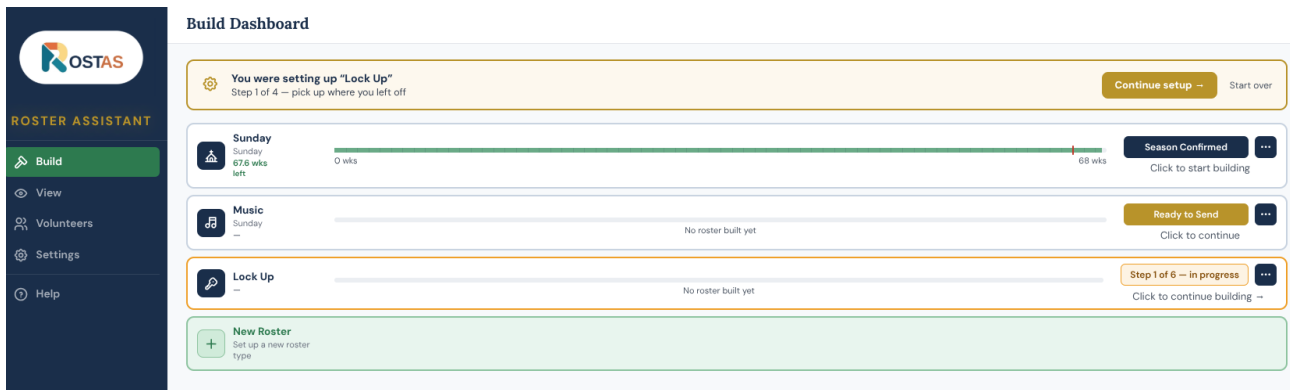
Separate from the roster's cadence, each volunteer has their own cap — how often *they* personally get rostered — so nobody is used every week just because they're always free. You set it on each person's profile (Frequency on the Profile detail page), independently for each roster they serve in. The two settings work together:

The cap counts distinct service dates, not individual roles. A volunteer in two roles on the same date counts as one service — so serving twice on one Sunday doesn't use two of their allocation.

The Roster Wizard

The Roster Wizard is the recurring roster cycle you run every few weeks. Each roster type has its own — the page is headed "[Your roster] Roster Wizard" — and it takes you through the same six named steps every time: Confirm Dates & Roles, Role Prefs, Availability, Build Roster, Check Roster, and Notify. A progress rail across the top shows where you are, marking each step Completed, Skipped, In progress, or still to come.

To start, open the **Builds** dashboard and click a roster's state button. If a build is already in progress, you're taken straight back to the step you left off at.



When a build is in progress, the roster's state button shows where it's up to and a resume banner appears at the top of the page. Click the state button to pick up where you left off.

Step 1 — Confirm Dates & Roles

This first step is where you confirm two things for the build: which **dates** it covers, and which **roles** (and how many people per role) are in play. Behind the scenes it also refreshes your seasons calendar and overlays public and school holidays, so the dates are correct before availability goes out.

Step 1 — Confirm Dates & Roles. The date bands show which dates are in this build; below them, a "Roles for this Build" panel lets you set the headcount and turn roles on or off for this build.

"Refresh & Sync" is an action within this step, not a step of its own. You may see a Refresh & Sync button here — it re-pulls the calendar and holidays. It's part of confirming your dates, which is why the step is named Confirm Dates & Roles.

Step 2 — Role Prefs

This step lets volunteers update their role preferences — which roles they're willing to perform. You can send a role-preference email to all volunteers, or skip the step entirely.

Step 2 — Role Prefs. Send emails so volunteers can set their own preferences, or use "Skip Role Preferences" if you manage them yourself.

This step is commonly skipped. Many coordinators set each volunteer's roles directly on the Profile page ahead of time, which makes this step unnecessary for that build — the rail simply marks it "Skipped" and you move on. Send the emails at the start of a new season or when new volunteers join; skip it for a routine mid-cycle build.

Step 3 — Availability

Rostas emails all active volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Each volunteer receives a personalised link — no login required. They tap their dates, mark any they can't make, and save.

Step 3 — send the availability request, then watch the response stats update as volunteers reply over the following days.

Allow 5-7 days for responses before moving to Step 4. Volunteers who don't respond within a configurable number of days automatically receive an SMS nudge.

Step 4 — Build Roster

With one click, the roster engine analyses every volunteer — their availability, role preferences, how recently they've served, and their frequency cap — and fills every slot automatically. The build takes about 30 seconds for most rosters.

Step 4 — one click builds the whole roster. The engine works through every slot using the four-tier priority system.

The engine uses a four-tier priority system — see Part A, The Intelligent Matching Engine for full detail on how slots are filled.

Step 5 — Check Roster

Before anything is sent to volunteers, you review what Rostas has built. Clicking **Open Roster Board** opens the board in review mode — you can see every assignment, make any manual changes, and return to the wizard. A Communications Preview lets you see exactly what each volunteer will receive before you send.

Step 5 — open the board to review assignments, or use the Communications Preview to check what volunteers will receive. When you're happy, mark it reviewed to proceed.

The board in review mode, opened from the wizard — click any cell to make a change, then return to the wizard when the roster looks right.

Don't skip this step. It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are notified. Check for unfilled slots, confirm the message wording looks right, and make any manual swaps needed.

Step 6 — Notify

Once you're satisfied with the roster, click **Send Notifications Now**. Every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments and a "Can't make it?" link.

Step 6 — Notify. With notifications sent, all six steps show complete on the rail and automatic reminders are queued. Start the next cycle whenever you're ready.

- Email reminder sent 3 days before each service date
- SMS reminder sent 1 day before each service date
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it" — the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

Confirming Build Dates

Before each build you confirm exactly which dates it covers, on the **Confirm Build Dates** screen. It lays out your roster's dates in coloured bands — so you can see what's already been built, what this build will cover, and what's coming after — and lets you drop any individual date you don't want rostered.

You reach it two ways: as the first step of a build (Confirm Dates & Roles), or on its own from the Builds dashboard — ... — **Manage Dates**.

The Confirm Build Dates screen — each date is a card, coloured by which band it belongs to.

Adjusting the dates

Click a card to turn it pink and remove it from the build. Click the blue arrows to change the last date built in the cycle — extending or shortening how far ahead this build reaches.

Holidays are tagged automatically. Dates that fall on a public holiday — Christmas Day, Labour Weekend, Waitangi weekend and the like — are labelled for you, and look distinct from dates you've excluded by hand, so you can tell an automatic holiday from a deliberate choice.

Excluding a date — a common example is the Sunday just after Christmas, when most people are away: click it to turn it pink and it drops out of the build.

Confirm early. Ideally do this a few weeks before the dates arrive, so there's time to collect availability and build. A **perpetual** roster rolls forward on its own, so each cycle you're simply confirming the next stretch of dates; a **fixed-term** roster is confirmed up to its end date. (See Frequency & Season Type for the difference.)

Editing dates on their own is safe. When you open this screen standalone via Manage Dates, your changes apply from the next build onward — dates already built are never altered.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **Boards** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, role columns across the top with green headers. Use the roster type tabs at the very top to switch between rosters. The legend and frequency search are in the header row above the grid.

Legend and Frequency

The legend row at the top of the board shows the four cell states. To the right, the **volunteer search** (with ◀▶ navigation arrows) lets you find a specific person and step through volunteers one by one. The **Frequency** panel shows how often the currently searched volunteer is rostered and when they were last assigned.

Taking Action on a Cell

Click any cell on the board to select it. The selected cell gets a navy border and a sticky action bar appears across the full width of the page — showing the volunteer's name, role, date, and current status, with action buttons on the right.

Clicking a cell opens the sticky action bar across the top, showing who is assigned, their role, date, and status. The available replacements panel drops in below, listing tiered candidates with Select buttons. The board grid remains visible behind it.

Swapping two volunteers

When two rostered volunteers want to trade dates, use **Swap with...** from the action menu. Click the first volunteer's cell, choose Swap with..., and that card is "armed" — it takes a gold border. Then click the cell you want to swap it with.

A card armed for swap — its gold border means Rostas is waiting for you to pick the card to swap it with.

A confirmation shows both volunteers, their roles and dates, so you can check the trade before committing.

Conflict warnings are advisory, not blocking. If a swap would clash — say a volunteer is already rostered elsewhere that day — Rostas shows amber warnings on the confirmation, but you can still go ahead. It flags the risk and leaves the decision to you.

A swap with conflicts — the amber warnings inform you, but the swap button stays available.

Manual Replacement

When you click **Replace**, the replacement panel appears below the action bar showing all available volunteers for that role and date, sorted by priority tier. Each volunteer shows their availability status and how recently they've been rostered.

The replacement panel — volunteers are grouped by tier. Click Select next to any volunteer to assign them immediately. The original volunteer is released and the new one is notified automatically.

The tiers match the engine. Tier 1 volunteers are available and have this as a primary role — the ideal replacement. Lower tiers are less ideal but still valid options. Pick the best fit for the situation.

The replacement volunteer is notified automatically. Once you click Select, Rostas sends them an SMS and email with their assignment details. You don't need to contact them separately.

Assigning a Second Role on the Same Date

Occasionally a volunteer may need to cover two roles on the same date — for example, stepping in for a missing team member while also serving in their usual role. Rostas supports this but flags it clearly so you're making a deliberate choice rather than an accidental double-booking.

A volunteer holding two roles on one date — Rostas shows both assignments clearly so it reads as a deliberate choice.

How to assign a second role

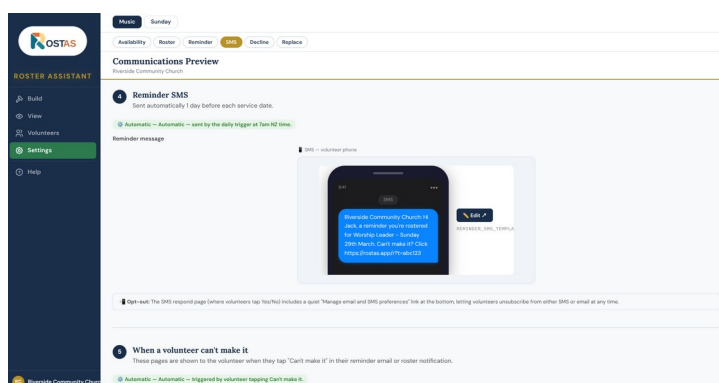
On the Volunteer detail page, navigate to the date in question. An amber collapsible section labelled **Second role — already rostered today** appears. Expand it to assign the additional role. The frequency cap counts this date only once regardless of how many roles are assigned on it.

Use this sparingly. Volunteers serving in multiple roles in one service can feel stretched. Always confirm with the volunteer before assigning a second role.

The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their notification email — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

The request text carries a **4-digit code** rather than a link — NZ networks filter many link-bearing texts, and a code is shorter and cheaper to send. The volunteer enters it at **rostas.app/enter** to reach the accept / decline page. See Part A for the full explanation of code entry.



The replacement request SMS — it carries a plain 4-digit code the volunteer enters at rostas.app/enter, rather than a link.

The page a volunteer reaches after tapping "Can't make it" — two clear options. If they changed their mind they can reinstate themselves on the spot.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent during your quiet hours (set in Settings → SMS, default 9pm–8am). If the chain reaches a volunteer inside that window it pauses automatically and resumes once quiet hours end. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Searching for a Volunteer

Use the search field at the top right of the board to find a specific volunteer. As you type, their assignments are highlighted across the entire board — making it easy to see all their upcoming dates at once. Use the ◀▶ arrows to step through volunteers alphabetically. The Frequency panel shows how often the current volunteer is rostered and when they last served.

Searching a volunteer highlights every one of their assignments across the board, so you can see their whole schedule at a glance.

Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement. Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar.

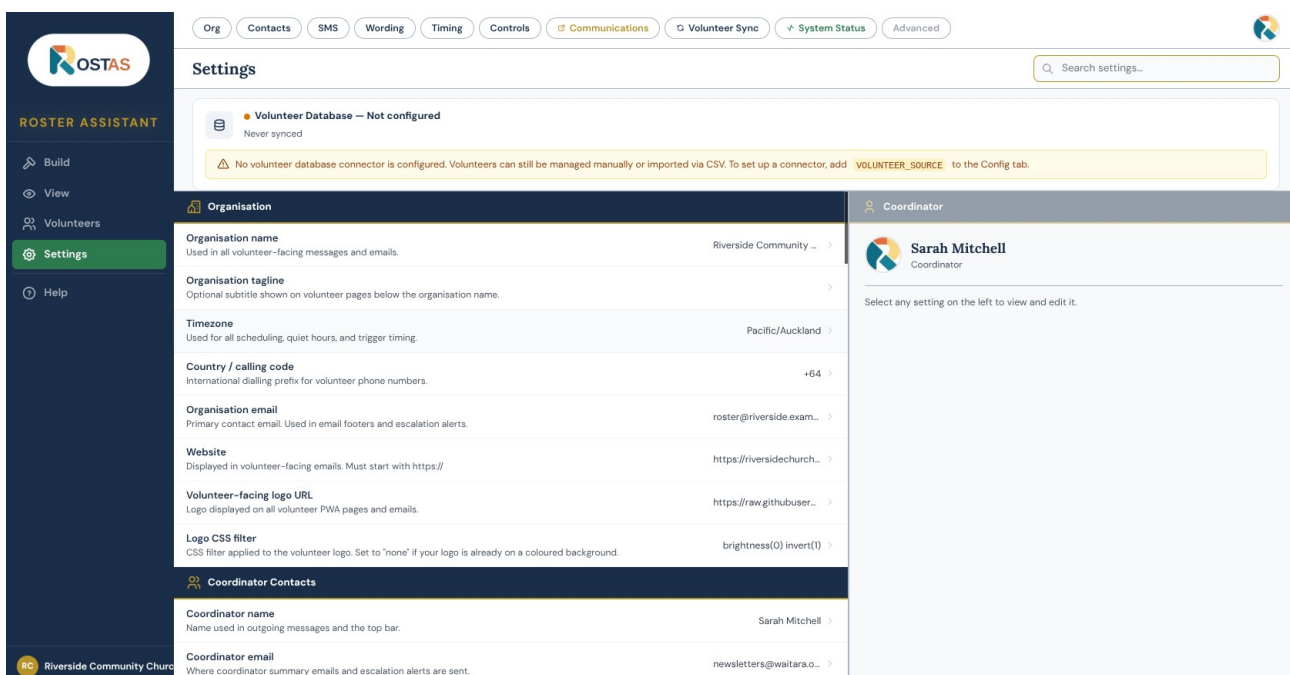
The Settings View

Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

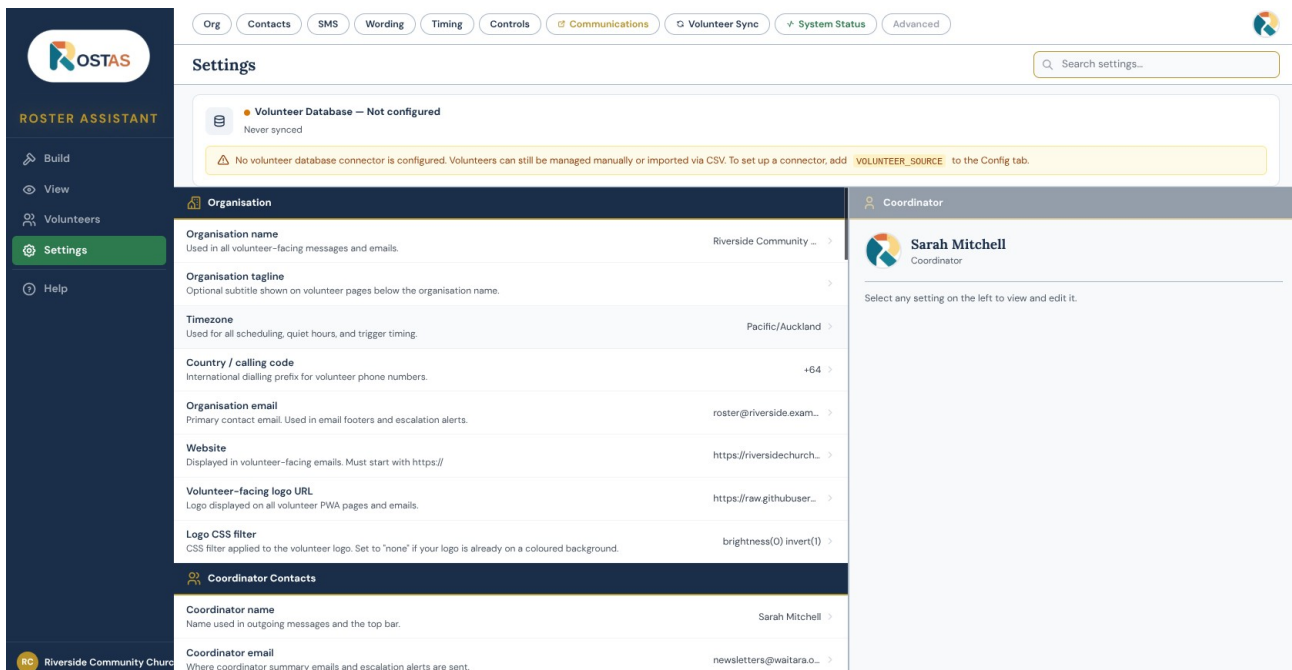
The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, System Status, and Advanced. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly. The **Communications** chip (gold, with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings...") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.



The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview. The System Status panel is visible at the top of the left panel.

The two-column layout

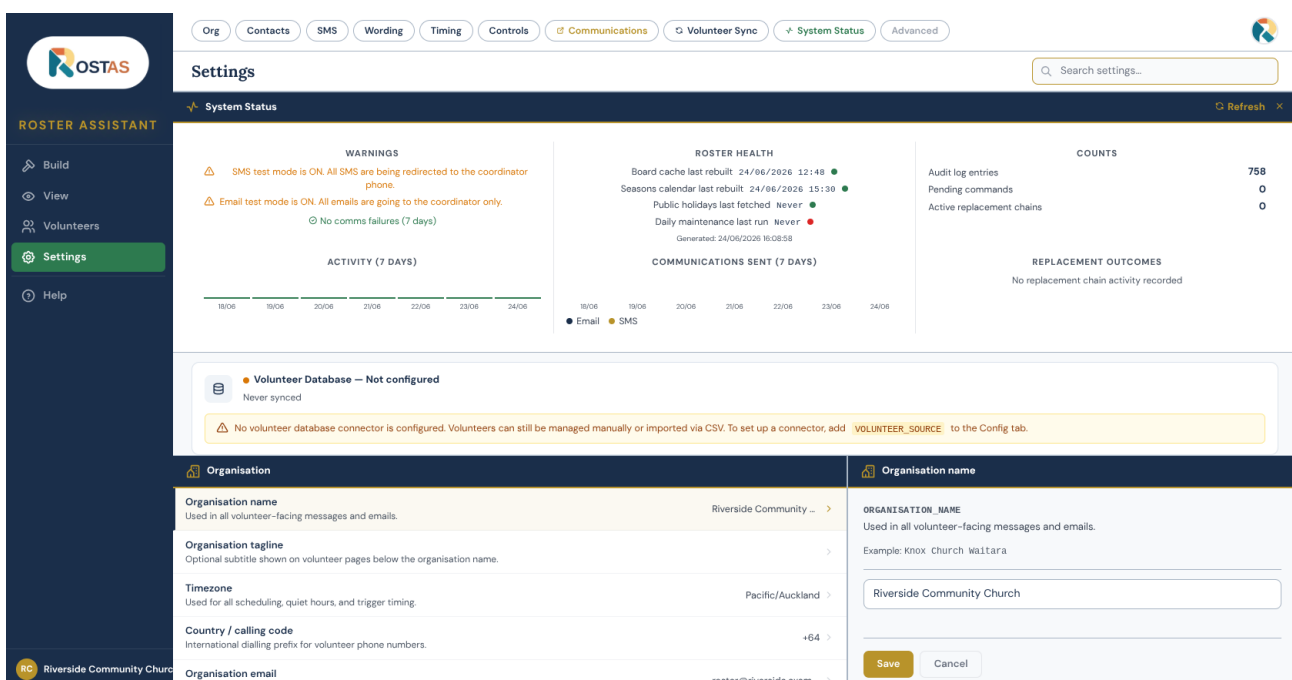


The two-column layout — categories and settings in the scrollable left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the sticky right panel.

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting



The right panel — key name at top, friendly label, full description, example value, and the input field. Validation runs as you type. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.

1. Click the row in the left panel. The right panel opens showing the setting name, description, and current value pre-filled in the input.
2. Make your change. The input type matches the setting — dropdowns for timezone and country code, toggles for on/off settings, text fields for everything else.
3. Validation runs as you type or on blur. If the value is invalid (wrong format, missing required content) the field turns red with an explanation. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.
4. Click **Save**. The left panel updates immediately to show the new value — no page reload needed.

Using System Status

The System Status card and the settings list below it are designed to work together. The card tells you what's wrong; the settings list is where you fix it.

Treat System Status as your starting point every time you open the Settings page. Before searching for a specific setting or making a planned change, glance at the Warnings column first. If it shows green — "All systems go" — you can proceed. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with tabs: Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications (selected), Volunteer Sync, System Status, and Advanced. Below this is the 'Settings' page header with a search bar. The main content area is titled 'System Status' and features a 'Refresh' button. It is divided into three columns: 'WARNINGS', 'ROSTER HEALTH', and 'COUNTS'. The 'WARNINGS' column shows two amber warnings: 'SMS test mode is ON. All SMS are being redirected to the coordinator phone.' and 'Email test mode is ON. All emails are going to the coordinator only.' Below these is a 'No comms failures (7 days)' indicator. The 'ROSTER HEALTH' column shows various system health indicators like 'Board cache last rebuilt', 'Seasons calendar last rebuilt', 'Public holidays last fetched', and 'Daily maintenance last run', all with green status indicators. The 'COUNTS' column shows 'Audit log entries' (758), 'Pending commands' (0), and 'Active replacement chains' (0). Below these columns is a 'REPLACEMENT OUTCOMES' section stating 'No replacement chain activity recorded'. At the bottom of the System Status panel, there's a 'Volunteer Database — Not configured' warning. Below the System Status panel is the 'Organisation' settings section, which includes fields for 'Organisation name', 'Organisation tagline', 'Timezone', 'Country / calling code', and 'Organisation email'. To the right of the Organisation settings is the 'Coordinator' section, which shows the name 'Sarah Mitchell' and a 'Select any setting on the left to view and edit it.' prompt.

The System Status panel — three columns showing current warnings, roster health indicators, and message counts. Check this panel if volunteers aren't receiving messages or something seems off.

Following a warning to its fix

Every warning in the System Status card maps directly to one or more settings in the list below. Rather than hunting through categories manually, use the search bar — the warning text itself usually contains the keyword you need:

The typical workflow is: see the warning → type the keyword into the search bar → click the matching row → fix it in the right panel → save. The whole thing takes under a minute once you know the pattern.

After making a change, check the card again

The System Status card doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click **Refresh** in the System Status card header to reload it and confirm the warning has cleared.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

Once warnings are clear, the lower sections of the card give you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand. Two of them are worth checking regularly.

- **Recent Activity** — a running list of the last twenty things Rostas did, newest first, across every level (routine actions, warnings, and errors). This is your first-stop diagnostic: if a volunteer says they didn't get a message, or you're not sure

whether a job ran, this list shows what actually happened and when. A steady stream of recent entries means Rostas is ticking over normally; a list whose newest entry is days old may mean the daily triggers have stopped running.

- **Communication Failures** — the most direct troubleshooting tool, shown in the Warnings column. When all is well it reads "No comms failures"; otherwise it lists recent send errors and warnings. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, check here for an entry on the date in question. If you see nothing at all for that date, the message may have been suppressed before sending — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours.

The card also shows activity and communications counts over the past seven days, plus replacement outcomes once you've run a few cycles. A high replacement-timeout rate can mean your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers reply, or that quiet hours are limiting the available sending window.

A coordinator who builds this habit — open Settings, check System Status, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do — will catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, and volunteer-facing logo. The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email, and mobile, plus per-roster coordinator contacts for Sunday, Music, Nourish, and any other roster types you've added. The per-roster contacts receive escalation alerts when a replacement chain is exhausted with no one found.
- **SMS** — the SMS kill switch, test mode toggle, quiet hours, and replacement timers. See SMS settings in detail below.
- **Message Wording** — every SMS template and email text block that Rostas sends to volunteers. SMS templates show a live character counter and required placeholder checker. See Message wording below.
- **Timing & Behaviour** — how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing, and public holiday region. The **Public holidays region** field includes a dropdown of supported countries and a "Fetch holidays now" button — use this to pull the latest public holidays for your country whenever you update this setting.
- **Quick Controls** — per-roster active toggles and email test mode. Useful for temporarily hiding a roster from the Build wizard without deleting it, or for switching email test mode on and off quickly.
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, roster type list, AWS SMS keys). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

SMS Settings in Detail

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

SMS enabled — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if your Twilio account lapses).

SMS test mode — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end are set as 24-hour values (e.g. 21 = 9pm, 8 = 8am). Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

Replacement timers — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Reminder SMS mode — controlling reminder texts

The day-before reminder text is the single biggest driver of SMS cost — one text per rostered volunteer, every service. The **Reminder SMS mode** setting decides who actually receives it. (The 3-day reminder *email* is unaffected and still goes to everyone with an email address.)

Reminder SMS mode — choose who gets the day-before text.

Email-first is the default, and the best value for most churches. It leans on free email and only spends a text where it'll actually help — someone with no email, or who hasn't confirmed. For the few volunteers who reliably miss email, turn on "Always text too" on their profile so they still get a text under Email-first.

Message Wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.

The screenshot displays the ROSTAS Settings interface. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Build, View, Volunteers, Settings (highlighted), and Help. The top navigation bar includes tabs for Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications, Volunteer Sync, System Status, and Advanced. The main content area is titled 'Settings' and features a search bar. A warning message states: 'Volunteer Database — Not configured. Never synced. No volunteer database connector is configured. Volunteers can still be managed manually or imported via CSV. To set up a connector, add VOLUNTEER_SOURCE to the Config tab.' The 'Message Wording' section lists various SMS templates with their descriptions and preview text. The 'Original volunteer released SMS' template is highlighted, showing its description, preview text, and a character count of 105 / 160. The preview text is: 'Hi [Name], no problem at all — we have found a replacement for [Role] on [Date]. — [OrgName] Roster Team.' The interface also includes a 'Preview SMS' button and a 'Save' button.

SMS template fields show a live character counter (105/160 in this example), the required placeholder list, and a Preview SMS button. The Save button is disabled if the message exceeds 160 characters or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Character counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea turns amber at 140 characters and red at 161+. The Save button is disabled when the count is red. The SMS templates are deliberately terse for this reason — when you edit one, the counter is protecting your church's SMS costs, not just formatting.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Code] — without it, the volunteer has no code to enter. (The equivalent email templates require [Link] instead.) Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → today's date, [Code] → a sample 4-digit code such as 4821). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, at the correct character count. It does not send a real SMS.

All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link], [Code], [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

The Message Wording category holds every message Rostas sends — the SMS templates (availability nudge, day-before reminder, replacement request, replacement confirmed, coordinator escalation) and the email templates (roster notification, availability request, reminder, swap). Edit any of them here; the three protections above apply to each.

The message-wording templates — each opens to an editor with its own character counter and required placeholders.

Two templates here are editable but not currently sent. The *Original volunteer released* SMS and the *Decline confirmation* SMS appear in the list and preview, but Rostas does not currently text the original volunteer when a replacement is found, nor the volunteer who declines. A volunteer who taps "Can't make it" sees a web page — "No problem — we'll find someone else" — rather than a text. You can edit their wording so it's ready, but don't rely on either going out yet.

Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

SMS Credits

Sending SMS costs money — unlike email, every text has a real per-message cost from the mobile networks. Rostas covers this with a simple prepaid credit system: **one credit sends one text**. Credits are used for reminders, replacement requests, and availability nudges, and they never expire — you top up whenever your balance runs low.

During the beta, SMS credits are free. Rostas covers the SMS costs for pilot churches, so there's nothing to buy and no balance to manage yet — the Buy buttons show a "coming soon" message for now. This section explains how credits will work once billing goes live, so there are no surprises.

The Buy SMS Credits page — four prepaid packs. The large number is how many texts the pack buys; the price is below it. Credits never expire.

Keeping SMS costs down. Reminders are the biggest driver of SMS use — one text per rostered volunteer before every service. If you'd like to stretch your credits further, email reminders cost nothing, and you can rely on SMS mainly for the time-sensitive replacement chain. Your Rostas contact can help you tune this.

Quick Controls

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.

The screenshot displays the 'Quick Controls' interface for SMS settings. It is divided into two main panels. The left panel, titled 'SMS', contains a list of settings: 'SMS enabled' (true), 'SMS test mode' (True), 'SMS quiet hours — start' (9:00 PM), 'SMS quiet hours — end' (8), 'Replacement timer — normal (minutes)' (120), 'Replacement timer — urgent (minutes)' (30), 'Replacement timer — panic (minutes)' (10), 'Twilio Account SID' (masked), 'Twilio Auth Token' (masked), and 'Twilio from number' (masked). The right panel, titled 'SMS enabled', shows a detailed view of the 'SMS_ENABLED' setting, which is currently turned on (indicated by a green toggle switch). Below the toggle are 'Save' and 'Cancel' buttons. The interface is designed to allow users to quickly toggle various SMS-related settings on or off.

Toggle fields in the right panel — a single switch with immediate visual feedback. The current state is always visible in the left panel list before you even click the row.

Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster. If SMS_TEST_MODE or EMAIL_TEST_MODE is True, volunteers will not receive any messages — only you will.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting: click the row, read the amber warning in the right panel, then click **Unlock to edit**. The field becomes editable. Save as normal.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings interface. The 'Advanced' tab is selected, and the 'Web app URL' setting is highlighted. The right panel shows the details for the 'Web app URL' setting, including a warning icon and the text 'ROSTER_ACTIVE_Nourish'. The 'Web app URL' is currently set to 'https://script.google.co...'. The 'Roster types' are set to 'Sunday'. The 'Infodile site code' is 'The part before .infodile.com in your Infodile URL'. The 'Infodile client ID' is 'OAuth client ID from Infodile admin settings'. The 'Infodile client secret' is 'OAuth client secret - keep this private'. The 'Infodile group IDs' are 'Comma-separated Infodile group IDs for volunteer sync'. The 'Infodile group map' is 'Maps Infodile group IDs to roster type names'.

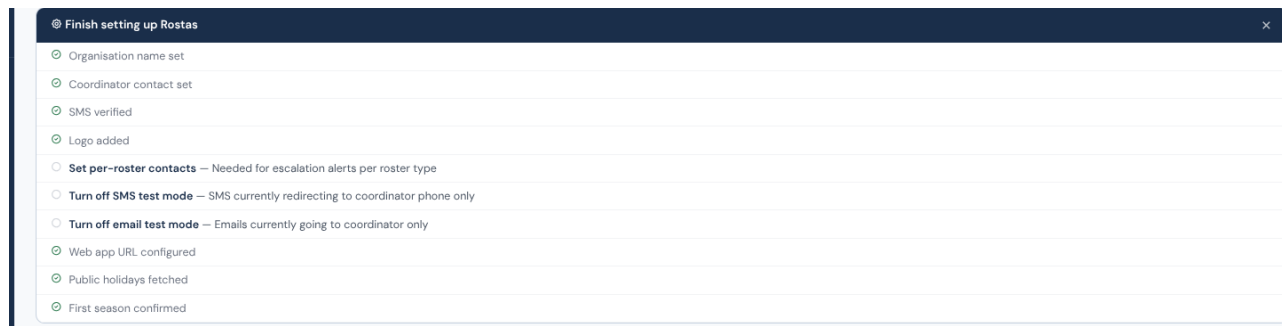
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and each row shows a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

The most common reason a coordinator needs the Advanced section is after redeploying Rostas — the **Web app URL** must be updated to match the new deployment URL. If short links in SMS stop working after a redeployment, this is almost always the cause.

Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention before going live. The checklist covers ten items — click any incomplete item to jump straight to the relevant setting.



The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete by reading the current Config values, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. Dismiss the checklist once all ten items are ticked.

The checklist stays visible until you dismiss it. Once all ten items are ticked, click Dismiss to clear it. It won't appear again. If you dismiss it with items still incomplete, you can still fix them through the normal settings list — the checklist is a guide, not a gate.

Troubleshooting

Most issues in Rostas fall into a small number of categories. Work through this list before contacting tech support.

Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages

- Check **Settings** → **Quick Controls** → **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check **SMS_TEST_MODE** is False — if True, all messages go to the coordinator only
- Check the volunteer's SMS toggle is On in their detail page
- Check quiet hours — SMS won't send between 9pm and 8am
- Check the volunteer's mobile number is in correct international format (+64...)
- Check the System Status communication failures table for error messages on the relevant date

Volunteers aren't receiving emails

- Check **EMAIL_TEST_MODE** is False in Quick Controls
- Check the volunteer's Email toggle is On in their detail page
- Ask the volunteer to check their spam/junk folder
- Confirm their email address is correct in their volunteer detail page

Roster has unfilled slots after building

- Check that enough volunteers have responded to the availability email
- Check that volunteers have role preferences set — without preferences set, the engine can't assign them to specific roles
- Check frequency caps — volunteers who've hit their monthly cap won't be assigned further
- Consider rebuilding after more availability responses come in
- Use manual replacement on the Board to fill remaining slots

SMS replacement chain isn't progressing

- Check quiet hours — chain pauses between 9pm and 8am and resumes automatically
- Check **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check there are eligible volunteers left on the backup list — if the list is exhausted you'll receive an escalation SMS
- Use manual replacement on the Board to assign someone directly

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the System Status communication failures table
- The web app URL has changed and volunteer links are broken
- You need to change Twilio or other API credentials
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- You need to add or remove a roster type
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

When contacting tech support, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot

of any error message or the System Status panel is very helpful.

Most organisations get their volunteers into Rostas by importing a CSV — it works for everyone and needs nothing more than a spreadsheet. But if your church already keeps its people in another system, a **connector** can sync them into Rostas automatically, so you don't maintain two lists by hand.

Connectors sync identity only. A connector brings across each person's *name, mobile, and email* — nothing more. Everything about *how* they serve — which rosters they're in, the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with — is set up and lives entirely inside Rostas. Your other system stays the source of truth for contact details; Rostas stays the source of truth for rostering.

Infoodle

Infoodle is the first connector available in Rostas. Once it's connected, new and updated contacts flow in on their own — a volunteer added in Infoodle appears in your Profiles list without a re-import, and a changed phone number or email updates itself.

When someone is removed in Infoodle, Rostas doesn't delete them out from under you. Instead it flags them with a **"Deleted in Infoodle"** marker in the Profiles list, so you can confirm they should go and remove them here deliberately — protecting you from losing a volunteer's history by accident.

Setting up the Infoodle connector is done with Rostas, not self-serve. The connection uses credentials that are provisioned for your church rather than entered by a coordinator — so if you'd like Infoodle sync switched on, contact support@rostas.app and it'll be set up for you.

Other connectors

Infoodle is the first of a growing family of connectors. Support for other church and volunteer platforms — such as Planning Center and Elvanto — is planned, so more organisations can sync rather than import over time.

Not on the list yet? These connectors are on the roadmap rather than available today, and CSV import works with every system in the meantime — most spreadsheets and databases can export a CSV. If a connector for your platform would help, let your Rostas contact know; it helps prioritise what's built next.

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